

The Other Operating System

Why this Fast Track on Linux? Well, mostly because we've spoken so much about it in *Digit*, and because there are many of you out there who, even then, have no clue that The Other Operating System can actually be used by human beings.

We don't aim here to give you high-flying tips—just a mild introduction, but we cover what's necessary for a first-timer to get started.

We start off with a history lesson, and with good reason: a knowledge of Linux's open source and community-driven beginnings is important to fully appreciate what it is today. Then follows a workshop-like chapter on how to get started using Linux—installation, post-installation procedures, some basic commands, and so on. File management in Linux is more "advanced" than in Windows—meaning you can play around more with the filesystem—and chapter 3 is therefore devoted entirely to files. Then follows, in chapter 4, a discussion of the X window system and the Gnome and K desktop environments.

Chapters 5 and 6 are about stuff you can do on Linux—text editing, image manipulation, multimedia—you'll find out for yourself later, but take our word for it now: Linux isn't only about kernel recompiling and C programming at a command prompt! We proceed to tell you how to use your Linux machine for gaming.

No discussion of Linux can be complete without talking about the networking aspect—because Unix and its derivatives are essentially server-oriented OSes—and that we do in chapter 7. And if you've decided by then that you want to try out a Linux distro (or flavour, if you like to call it that), chapter 8 is about the differences between the most common distros, and their salient features.

We round off the book with a discussion of system administration in Linux, and finally, we point you to Web resources.

It's our sincere hope that even if you don't actually make the switch from Windows, you will experiment a little to get an idea of the variety of choices you have!